

BLOCK 4
HEALTH JOURNALISM

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Introduction

Unit 14 Ethics and Values in Health Journalism serves as the ethical compass for health journalists. Delving into the issues of responsible journalism, it covers ethical considerations in handling sources, reporting practices, and navigating medico-legal complexities. This unit aims to instil a deep understanding of the moral dimensions inherent in health reporting, ensuring accuracy, integrity, and sensitivity in the dissemination of health-related information.

Unit 15 Role and Responsibilities of Health Journalist unfolds the multifaceted roles and responsibilities of health journalists. It delves into essential skills required for effective health reporting, encompassing a range of reporting types and techniques. From interpreting complex health data to presenting information responsibly, this unit empowers students with the diverse skill set needed to navigate the challenges and opportunities in health journalism.

Unit 16 Behavioural Change Communication in Health Care addresses the strategic aspect of health journalism by focusing on behavioural change communication in healthcare. It explores various channels, strategies, and guidelines for communicating health information effectively. Students will gain insights into shaping public perceptions, fostering positive health behaviours, and utilising media for impactful health communication.

Block 4 serves as a gateway into the realm of health journalism, covering ethical considerations, research practices, essential skills, and strategies for effective communication. Through these units, we aim to empower you with the knowledge and tools necessary to navigate the dynamic landscape of health communication in the digital age.

UNIT 14 ETHICS AND VALUES IN HEALTH JOURNALISM

Structure

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14.0 INTRODUCTION

Health Journalism: Widespread undernourishment, malnutrition, abysmal conditions of primary health care systems and many such issues plaguing the healthcare system of our country elevates our role as health journalists. Health journalists have a duty to report on such issues ethically, accurately and with a lot of integrity. In other words, it endows us with a sense of responsibility towards the public by shining a light on healthcare issues that affect us directly or indirectly. The recent coronavirus pandemic which left thousands of people dead has ignited a debate on health reforms within the country. It has called for easy accessibility and more equitable distribution of healthcare facilities across different sections of society.

14.1 LEARNING OUTCOMES

After working through this unit, you will be able to:

- comprehend the status of health journalism in India;

- know about different issues plaguing the healthcare system in the country;
- understand the challenges faced by health journalists; and
- gain an insight into ethical challenges while reporting on health issues in India.

14.2 UNDERSTANDING HEALTH JOURNALISM

Health sector has a significant role to play in a country's progress report. Several yardsticks, which include public life expectancy, maternity & mortality rate, no. of children suffering from malnourishment, serve as significant factors in understanding how well placed a country is within the human development index. Health journalists must understand the bearings of such issues within a country's health framework. They should be able to decipher scientific content and de-jargonize complex scientific terms for their general audience. Journalists covering the health sector must stay informed about new developments taking place in the field of health around the world. From latest discovery of vaccines to cutting edge scientific research, health journalism is a field which is continuously evolving and growing. Hence, health journalists have a responsibility to report accurately and effectively. They must realize that they have the power to shape public opinion and influence policymakers. Hence sensitive information should be relayed with caution, keeping in mind the consequences and far-reaching impact that such stories can have on their audience.

14.3 DISSEMINATION OF HEALTH NEWS

Mass media plays a crucial role in disseminating information.

People often rely on mass media to garner information on issues related to health, such as personal hygiene, communicable and non-communicable diseases, health policies and so on. For example---A doctor's interview on impact of certain food on body systems can influence lifestyle changes among readers. In the age of the Internet, dissemination of information is rather quick. It can be done through print, TV, radio, or social media. This ready and quick availability of information also presents us with challenges. An overload of information makes it difficult for readers to sift through vast trove of information and differentiate between fake & genuine news. An example of this was clearly visible during the pandemic where misinformation was abundant, compelling reliable sources (government and genuine news media organizations) to intervene and relay accurate information from time to time to avoid panic among public.

14.4 UNDERSTANDING ETHICS OF HEALTH JOURNALISM

Accuracy and sticking to the facts remain the cornerstone of good journalism. In the age of TRPs and revenue driven model that most news organizations are grappling with, speed and breaking news syndrome have taken a toll on accuracy and objectivity. Hence, there needs to be a revival of journalism ethics. Most importantly, journalists should be mindful of scaremongering and

sensationalism when it comes to health journalism. Sensationalism not only causes cultural corruption, but it can also sabotage effective measures employed by organizations to combat a situation. The pandemic was a clear example of how scaremongering and unfiltered information pouring in through social media caused panic among people. Given the context of the story, it is very important that the identity of people who are part of case studies be protected and secured.

Sensitive information should not be made public. Avoid identifying people based on religion or caste as this can lead to stereotyping. Additionally, always seek the opinion of health experts who can shed light on issues precisely and accurately.

14.5 ETHICS OF INTERVIEWING

Developing and cultivating sources are significant to journalistic endeavour. One should always check the credibility of their sources. In other words, journalists should check if the sources are knowledgeable enough to give their views on a topic. Insist that your source must go on record while you are interviewing them. It can get quite dicey if your sources insist that they should be anonymous. In letting yourself quote anonymous sources there is always a possibility that your sources could go back on what they have said, and your news organization could be forced to retract the story. So, cultivate sources carefully and as much as possible avoid quoting anonymous sources. In case a source has tipped you off on a story or a happening, it is important for you as a journalist to protect the identity of the source under every circumstance. One should never compromise on that front.

14.6 CULTIVATING SOURCES

Networking is a significant way to cultivate sources. Meet your source in person and try to be in touch with them even when you are not chasing a story. The relationship between you and your sources should be more than just give and take.

As a journalist it is important that you should never lie to your sources. It is paramount to keep the intent of the story clear. And most importantly, quote your sources accurately. Never twist their words. Always quote them verbatim. This is significant to gain their trust. Also, this will make it easier for you as a journalist to approach your sources next time for your story. Also, once the story is published it is important to inform your sources that they have been quoted. From time to time, it is significant to check on them. This is significant for networking purpose. Relationship between journalists and their sources should be sheerly based on trust. No other mode of transaction (money, gifts, etc) should be involved.

14.7 HANDLING SENSITIVE INFORMATION

A journalist should assess risks associated with a story. Accordingly, precautions must be taken. In the digital age this could be protecting information obtained from a source that you have tucked away in your computer. It is important to ensure that this information should be protected.

According to Committee to Protect Journalists, “Protecting confidential sources is a cornerstone of ethical reporting. When journalists have agreed to protect someone’s identity, they should make every effort to do so, especially in circumstances where a source could be arrested or harmed.” Different ways to do that could include taking precautionary measures which involve digital safety best practices. This could be done by employing layers of security by building strong passphrase or using two-factor authentication (2FA). It is important to remove browser history and regularly update your devices. Using encryption during chats is another way to secure information. Additionally, it is important to make sure that the source you are talking to is authentic and has information that could be valuable to you. A classic example of this could be studied through whistleblower Edward Snowden and how he passed on sensitive information to journalists which finally blew the lid on NSA’s mass surveillance program.

14.8 REPORTING THE PANDEMIC

Media as a fourth pillar of democracy has an important role in bringing about change in society. It is also endowed with responsibility of bringing about positive changes within society and shed light on issues. During the pandemic, media became the source of information for most people. The government had used media to broadcast timely information on the pandemic. During the lockdown period media organizations served as the most reliable source of information for public. News media organizations also had to grapple with initial stages of reporting about coronavirus when there was clearly lack of knowledge or information about coronavirus, its nature, mode of transmission etc.

During an epidemic messaging plays a very important role. We saw that from time-to-time. Clear messages were being reinforced by both the government as well as various media organizations. Mass media played a huge role in keeping people informed about the surge in covid cases. People were asked to wear masks and maintain social distancing.

In a paper titled, “Making waves in India: Media and the COVID-19 pandemic,” the authors argue that it becomes “imperative for the media and the government to repeatedly, perhaps in a novel manner, convey messages to the public regarding NPIs to the public to lessen the impact of the disease, primarily when the prevalence of the disease is in a downward trend.”

Please note, NPI here means non-pharmaceutical interventions (NPIs) which include physical distance, hand hygiene, wearing a mask, etc. to limit the spread of the disease.

The paper which was published in *Brookings Institution* goes on to emphasize that the role of media becomes more important during a pandemic. “This did not happen on the eve of the second wave, and the lack of relevant information likely intensified the disastrous impact of the wave,” the authors say.

Check Your Progress: 1

Note: 1) Use the space provided below for your answers.

2) Compare your answers with those given at the end of the unit.

1. What are the risks associated with news gathering through social media?

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14.9 VERIFYING NEWS THROUGH SOCIAL MEDIA

Social media comes with its own risks. The advent of social media has definitely played a crucial role in dissemination of information and improving outreach. However, it also comes with certain risks. Misinformation & abundant fake news are flooding through social media. This puts users at risk. News through social media travels very fast. This can cause a lot of panic among people. This is precisely what happened during the pandemic. According to a recent study on “The Negative Impact of Social Media during COVID-19 Pandemic,” there was a positive association between social media and fear associated with the spread of COVID-19. While it was clear that people used social media for interaction and for keeping themselves updated and informed about the pandemic, the study suggested that “the influence of social media on respondents’ terror levels varies based on their age and gender.” The study further informs that government should collaborate with proper agencies to “offer people reliable COVID-19 resources and timely advice. It is also recommended that the government take action to punish people with huge followings who spread unsupported notions to the general population.”

As journalists it is important to think critically. It is important to call sources to verify information. In case of information which appears exaggerated, it is important to cross-check with co-workers or sources. Instead of verifying through secondary sources, it is always important to check primary sources. Verifiable official accounts are some of the best sources of information to gather on Twitter.

14.10 FAKE NEWS

Fake news is defined as false news or fabricated information which can be sufficiently misleading or inaccurate. Then there are two different types of ‘fake news’- a term which has risen in prominence since 2016. One that is completely fabricated news and the other kind of news which is sufficiently misleading or inaccurate (Trehan & Papanikitas, 2020). However, it is important to understand that fake news is different from poor reporting. Poor reporting can often happen when there is dilution of the facts unlike fake news which when widely shared can endanger a health crisis or can even cause a situation to go out of hand. Now the World Health Organization (WHO) says that infodemic happens when there is too much information (including false and misleading

information) present in digital and physical environments during a disease outbreak. “It causes confusion and risk-taking behaviours that can harm health. It also leads to mistrust in health authorities and undermines the public health response. An infodemic can intensify or lengthen outbreaks when people are unsure about what they need to do to protect their health and the health of people around them. With growing digitization – an expansion of social media and internet use – information can spread more rapidly. This can help to fill information voids more quickly but can also amplify harmful messages,” states WHO.

From SARS to Ebola to COVID-19, there was an upsurge of fake news during health crises. In the first three months of 2020, some 6000 people around the world were hospitalized due to misinformation around coronavirus. According to research, an estimated 800 people might have died due to spread of misinformation related to COVID-19.

Fake news can spread through bogus URLs, fake video screen grabs & misleading tweets. To detect whether the news is fake or not, it is important to check the original source of information. Sometimes a careful Google Search can inform whether the news has been widely reported or not. Most news organizations are quick to identify such news. Also, it is important to utilize services of several fact checking websites such as Factcheck.org that lists fake news.

14.11 MEDICO LEGAL ISSUES

A medical case becomes a medico legal issue when a doctor examining the patient informs the law enforcement agency about the case. Such cases can include death by suicide, any accident, rape cases, etc. When it comes to road accidents, it becomes mandatory for the doctor to examine the patient. In *Parmanand Katara vs. Union of India* case, the Supreme Court pronounced a judgement making it obligatory or compulsory for doctors or any healthcare professional, working in private or in public hospitals, to take immediate medical aid or attend victim who is injured in any kind of accident without any delay or any further process of any legal process. However, in recent scenario, there have been several instances when doctors have been attacked by relatives of victims. On that front, the Indian Medical Association (IMA) insisted on implementation of the new medico legal protocol to ensure safety of healthcare professionals.

14.12 ETHICAL ISSUES WHILE REPORTING

Ethics is of paramount importance while reporting. Covering point of view from all sides, talking to genuine sources, covering all sides of a story are some of the core areas of ethics. In the age of paid news, it is very important for journalists to remember that accepting any kind of money (in kind or cash) for the purpose of doing a story is unethical. Any kind of favoritism or impartiality while reporting or writing a story is wrong. A journalist should be objective while reporting a story. It is important that journalists should not indulge in any lobbying activities or represent any special interest groups. Journalists should remember that their duty is to report the truth and that they are not PR executives.

In other words, honesty and independence are significant traits of journalists. It is also significant that journalists do not choose sides and ally themselves to any political affiliations. Journalists should exhibit balance in their reporting and cover as many POVs (point of view) as possible to ensure that no side has been left out. It is important for journalists to understand the importance of fairness and public accountability. Journalism as a public service and should be treated as such. Accountability to the public is significant for journalists. The Bofors scandal which resulted in the fall of the then Congress government is an example of remarkable investigative journalism that held the government accountable.

Journalists must be careful when they work with children, rape victims or any other sensitive story. While covering such stories it is important for journalists not to reveal the identity of the victims as it can have significant consequences for the victim.

In the race for TRP and readership, it is important that journalists stay away from unnecessary sensationalism. Printing incorrect information or false information can be damaging to a person's reputation. So before printing or broadcasting anything journalists should verify and cross-check. Most importantly, journalists should give proper attribution to quotes or while quoting sources. Journalists should also never plagiarize. Their writings should be original. Most significantly, Journalists must follow deadlines which are extremely important and very crucial in a news cycle.

Check Your Progress: 2

Note: 1) Use the space provided below for your answers.

2) Compare your answers with those given at the end of the unit.

1. What are the key things one should keep in mind while dealing with sources?

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14.13 SOCIAL RESPONSIBILITY

Social responsibility is a very strong component of health journalism and journalistic ethics in general. Social responsibility is supremely important for journalists. If media organizations are completely consumed by stories which are politically motivated or sensational in nature, it can cause cultural corruption among the masses. Therefore, it becomes significant for journalists to do responsible reporting. Within a democratic set up the significance of independent media cannot be overlooked. Therefore, it becomes important for media organizations to cover pressing issues in society which demand attention. All around, if one observes there has been a significant decline in investigative journalism. This kind of journalism, which requires a lot of patience and money, is becoming rare nowadays. In the age of breaking news and multimedia journalism it becomes important for media organization to keep this rare breed

of investigative journalists alive. Another area is in the field of developmental journalism or rural reporting where there needs to be more focus. Alternate platforms like Khabar Lahariya, an Indian newspaper published in various rural dialects, are filling the gap for mainstream media. A very interesting movie called Nero's Guests based on suicide of farmers in Vidarbha is a good example of how mainstream media missed this very important story.

When it comes to health reporting, it is important that media organizations should prioritize the safety of journalists. During the outbreak of swine flu, SARS and the Covid, many journalists were exposed to vulnerable situations. In such cases, journalists should never prioritize their health & life over a story. And media organizations and journalists must remember that no story is worth dying for.

Check Your Progress: 3

- Note:** 1) Use the space provided below for your answers.
2) Compare your answers with those given at the end of the unit.
1. What should journalists remember while covering a story?

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14.14 LET US SUM UP

In this Unit on ethics and values in health journalism, we learnt about pressing issues on health issues plaguing our country. We discussed challenges that health reporters face while covering health stories. We discussed responsibilities that journalists have when they cover stories. We learnt about challenges posed by the pandemic. We discussed accountability and social responsibilities that journalists have towards public. We learnt about advantages and disadvantages of social media. We discussed the importance of fake news and proper attribution.

14.15 KEYWORDS

Infodemic: An infodemic is too much information including false or misleading information in digital and physical environments during a disease outbreak. It causes confusion and risk-taking behaviours that can harm health. It also leads to mistrust in health authorities and undermines public health response. An infodemic can intensify or lengthen outbreaks when people are unsure about what they need to do to protect their health and the health of people around them. With growing digitization – an expansion of social media and internet use – information can spread more rapidly. This can help to fill information voids more quickly but can also amplify harmful messages. (Credit: WHO)

Epidemic: An epidemic is a sudden disease outbreak that affects a large number of people in a particular region, community, or population.

Pandemic: A pandemic is **the worldwide spread of a new disease**

14.16 FURTHER READINGS

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[Tips to help journalists protect themselves online | International Journalists' Network \(ijnet.org\)](#)

[Making waves in India: Media and the COVID-19 pandemic | Brookings](#)

14.17 CHECK YOUR PROGRESS: POSSIBLE ANSWERS

Check Your Progress: 1

Ans: Misinformation & abundant fake news are flooding through social media. This puts users at risk. News through social media travels very fast. This can cause a lot of panic among people. This is precisely what happened during the pandemic.

Check Your Progress: 2

Ans: Developing and cultivating sources are significant to journalistic endeavour. One should always check the credibility of their sources. In other words, they should check if the sources are knowledgeable enough to give their views on a topic. Insist that your source must go on record while you are interviewing them.

Check Your Progress: 3

Ans: Covering point of view from all sides, talking to genuine sources, covering all sides of a story are some of the core areas of ethics. In the age of paid news, it is very important for journalists to remember that accepting any kind of money (in kind or cash) for the purpose of doing a story is unethical. Any kind of favoritism or impartiality while reporting or writing a story is wrong. A journalist should be objective while reporting a story. It is important that journalists should not indulge in any lobbying activities or represent any special interest groups. Journalists should remember that their duty is to report the truth and that they are not PR executives.

UNIT 15 ROLES AND RESPONSIBILITIES OF HEALTH JOURNALISTS

Structure

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- 15.1 Learning Outcomes
- 15.2 Brief Overview and Significance of Health Journalism
 - 15.2.1 Significance of Public Awareness about Health and Related Issues
 - 15.2.2 Impact of Health Journalism on Public Health Policies
- 15.3 Essential Skills for Health Journalists
 - 15.3.1 Research and Investigation Techniques
 - 15.3.1.1 Selecting the Right Studies:
 - 15.3.2 Relative Risk Vs Absolute Risk
 - 15.3.3 Inferences from Practicing Health Journalists
 - 15.3.4 Contextualisation
 - 15.3.5 Medical Literacy
- 15.4 Health Policy Reporting
 - 15.4.1 Analyzing the Role of Health Journalists in Covering Healthcare Policies
 - 15.4.2 Understanding the Influence of Policy Decisions on Public Health
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 - 15.5.2 Navigating Sensitive Topics with Empathy and Professionalism
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 - 15.6.1 Addressing the Challenges and Responsibilities of Reporting on Mental Health
 - 15.6.2 Destigmatizing Mental Health Through Accurate and Compassionate Journalism
- 15.7 Global Health Journalism
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 - 15.8.2 Leveraging Social Media Responsibly in Health Journalism
- 15.9 Handling Health Data and Experts
 - 15.9.1 Communicating Health Data
 - 15.9.2 Building Relationships with Health Professionals

15.0 INTRODUCTION

Health journalism involves the spread of all types of health-related information through media outlets to the public. Like new medicines, health policies, the results of medical research, the benefits of immunization, disease outbreaks and how to stop them, and anything else that would keep people up to date and help them take smart decisions about their health. In other words, health journalism assists in developing some level of health literacy among the public.

Healthy People 2010 defines health literacy as the knowledge and skills people need to manage their health in a health care system that is becoming more complicated (Hinnant & Len-Rios, 2009). For example, how often they see their doctor or how much they trust vaccines. When there was a controversy over the safety of the measles, mumps, and rubella (MMR) vaccine, it was critical health journalism that helped clear the air. Health journalists can influence, educate, and change the attitude and belief of the public towards a particular health issue, encourage healthy practices, and also bring health related concerns to the attention of authorities. Through their reporting, they can get people to support health policies that are good for them.

Hence, health reporters must work hard to give accurate, thorough, and reliable news because any of these things could mislead the public and force lawmakers to make laws and rules that may not work or are even harmful. A mass vaccination effort may fail, for instance, if incidental mild events that follow vaccination are reported in an inflated way.

15.1 LEARNING OUTCOMES

At the end of the course, you will be able to

- understand the significance of health reporting;
- implement effective research techniques for factual health reporting; and
- apply principles of ethical reporting.

15.2 BRIEF OVERVIEW AND SIGNIFICANCE OF HEALTH JOURNALISM

15.2.1 Significance of Public Awareness About Health and Related Issues

Understanding health issues and their causes can help people stay healthy by adopting the right attitudes, taking preventative measures, and using control strategies like vaccination, hygiene, and lifestyle choices. By showing how diet, sleep, and exercise prevent CVDs and diabetes, people may adopt them. Similarly, raising awareness of the dangers of smoking, binge drinking, and drug use may reduce their prevalence.

Health awareness empowers people to make informed health decisions and be proactive by seeking consultations or screenings. In addition, it builds empathy and lowers stigma. For example, raising awareness busts myths about mental health and encourages support. Making people more aware of and knowledgeable about health issues can lower the cost of long-term and preventable illnesses. In fact, a key component of disease outbreak control is spreading accurate and reliable information during times of public health emergencies. Early awareness of the illness outbreak would help in understanding risk behaviour and enable the public to react swiftly to the outbreak. In addition to lessening the overall strain on healthcare systems, early detection and action can stop the spread of infectious diseases. All of us have witnessed the importance of this during the COVID-19 pandemic. The mass media, which are the main ways that health messages get out, were used to tell people how to prevent and treat diseases, as well as government rules they needed to follow during the pandemic.

Public awareness and understanding of health issues and conditions can serve another crucial role, that of national health management, by aiding in effective healthcare resource allocations and focusing governmental attention on prevalent health problems and challenges. Further, it could also lead to the mobilization of support for advantageous public health policies. More about this will be discussed under subsection 16.2.2. Raising people's awareness of health issues would also lead to global health cooperation. Such as working together to solve health problems that many countries share. Sharing information will also make it easier to share the best ways to do things and build global health efforts.

15.2.2 Impact of Health Journalism on Public Health Policies

Studying how health journalism affects public health policies is a complicated and multidimensional field that touches on the relationship between the media, healthcare, and policymaking. Participation and public involvement are essential results of good health journalism. Through promoting public awareness and participation in health policy dialogues, health journalism enables people to make knowledgeable decisions about their health and supports neighbourhood-based projects.

The effective execution of public health policy can be impacted by media coverage due to its ability to mould public attitudes, rally support, and encourage adherence. Social media, podcasts, and other emerging technologies have a significant influence on the narratives surrounding health and policy. Outside the sphere of information distribution, health journalism has a major role in influencing public opinion and establishing political agendas pertaining to health. By drawing attention to important issues and affecting how resources and attention are allocated in government, journalists have the ability to highlight certain health-related concerns through their reporting. In addition, health journalism is essential for assessing the effects of policies, holding decision-makers responsible for their actions, and offering insightful commentary for the creation of new policies.

The influence does, however, come with obligations and difficulties, highlighting the significance of truthful information sharing, moral reporting,

and the ongoing modification of journalistic techniques to fit the changing media environment. According to the Association of Health Care Journalists (AHCJ), professional standards of truth, accuracy, and context in every report are absolutely necessary for health-care journalists. To do this, health journalists need to be cautious when selecting their sources, investigate and record any relationships between information sources and proponents of novel ideas or treatments, understand how medical research functions so that they can report accurately, use television library or file footage sparingly, avoid using language that is unclear or sensational, and weigh the benefits and risks of the story. They should be responsible and check their facts before they write stories. Spreading false information can hurt the public's trust in public health programs and make them less effective. In 1998, the Lancet published a poorly designed study that suggested a connection between autism and the measles, mumps, and rubella (MMR) vaccine. This link was later disproved. After the study came out, childhood vaccination rates dropped for years in the UK, Ireland, and the USA. This was because the study was widely reported in the media. This shows that false scientific information in the media can make people less trusting of vaccinations. The effects of using the media to disseminate scientific research when it contains false information, as in the case of the MMR can lead to public misunderstanding, distrust in science, and harmful health behaviours (Dempster, G., Sutherland, G., & Keogh, L., 2022).

To help create public-resonant strategies, health journalists must work in tandem with legislators, health experts, and communication professionals. People are more likely to understand and act on health information that is presented in an interesting way, such as through stories, graphics, and other methods that make it easier for them to find and use. Further, health journalists must effectively navigate social media areas to guarantee that the public receives accurate and trustworthy health information because of the speed and scope of information transmission through these platforms.

The impact of health journalism on public health policies varies depending on the nation and culture. The ways in which health journalism and its impact on policymaking are approached vary depending on the media environment, cultural perspectives on health, and the social role of journalism.

Check Your Progress: 1

Notes: 1) Use the space below for your answer.

2) Compare your answers with those ones given at the end of this unit.

1. In what ways do health journalists serve as intermediaries between scientific research and the general public?

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2. How do health journalists navigate the ethical considerations surrounding reporting on sensitive health topics?

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3. Analyze the role of health journalists in debunking myths and misinformation related to health issues?

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15.3 ESSENTIAL SKILLS FOR HEALTH JOURNALISTS

15.3.1 Research and Investigation Techniques

15.3.1.1 Selecting the Right Studies:

Health journalists have to deal with some specialised problems. It is helpful to have certain skills, knowledge, and good judgement. One of the main issues among journalists covering scientific subjects appears to be a lack of scientific competence. If you are a health reporter, you should be able to judge the quality of a paper by looking at whether the techniques and sample size were enough and whether the level of evidence and findings were important enough to be covered. Information from studies that are not well planned should not be shared unless the flaws are made clear.

Studies have shown that the way the media talk about randomized clinical trials and observational studies is not very different from one another. In fact, journalists have been accused of ignoring the importance of carefully choosing research articles that are based on evidence. In evidence-based medicine, a study is given a score based on where it stands on the evidence pyramid. At the top of the pyramid are systematic reviews of randomized, controlled trials. Randomized controlled trials that are well-designed come in second, and observational studies come in third. Case and bench studies, such as animal and in vitro studies, are at the very bottom.

Further, in this age of interconnectedness, journalists need to look into and report on any possible conflicts of interest between health information sources and people who are pushing a new idea or therapy. Because these kinds of conflicts may not be obvious, reporters have to look for them all the time as they do research for stories and talk to people. They need to look into and report any possible connections between researchers and private companies, researchers and public institutions, patient advocacy groups and the companies that fund them, celebrity spokespeople and the companies that fund them, and nonprofit health and professional organizations and the companies that fund them. If they don't, journalists might unintentionally spread skewed, biased, and incomplete news and information (Schwitzer, G., et al., 2005).

Journalist's Resource, an open-access online magazine for reporters, suggests a list of questions that reporters could use to identify and select studies. Even though it can be difficult to be sure of a study's quality, these questions can help you stay away from studies that are biased or otherwise flawed. Most of these questions are relevant to quantitative research, which looks at data from the natural and social sciences.

Is this research peer-reviewed? Peer-reviewed journals subject studies to rigorous review by qualified scholars. Even though peer review is imperfect, it maintains quality.

Did it appear in a top academic journal? Top journals publish better research. These journals publish carefully selected research. They also have stricter peer review.

Is the study trusted by other scholars? The reliability of a study can be judged by how many times it is cited by other researchers.

Who provided the research's funding? Knowing who funded the research and how they influenced its design, implementation, and public presentation is crucial. Funding sources for researchers must be disclosed in scholarly publications.

What credentials do the authors hold? You can evaluate an author's expertise in a field of study by learning where they work and how frequently their work has been published.

When was the study conducted? A study that is several years old might not be valid anymore.

Is there a potential conflict of interest for the authors? It is advisable to steer clear of studies conducted by individuals or organizations with vested interests in the outcomes.

What is the sample size? Results from larger samples are usually more accurate than those from smaller samples.

Does the study make use of survey data? In the event that respondents were not chosen through random selection, survey results could be skewed. Surveys that rely on respondents' voluntary participation should be avoided (such as a lot of online surveys).

Is the methodology used in conducting the research clearly stated? Researchers need to provide an explanation of their research methodology, including how they addressed their research questions and where and how they used their data. Key concepts and statistical procedures must be defined precisely by researchers. Giving sufficient information enables others to confirm and replicate the study.

Is statistical information included in the content? The data under examination and the numerical outcomes of the authors' analyses should be presented in detail. This makes their calculations reviewable by others.

Does the data support the study's findings? Good researchers carefully describe their conclusions to convey what they learned. Researchers may exaggerate or minimize their findings, or the data may contradict what an author claims to have found.

Is this research a meta-analysis? Meta-analyses, or meta-studies, are among the most trustworthy types of research. Their conclusions are derived from a review of several studies conducted on the same subject.

15.3.2 Relative Risk Vs Absolute Risk

Even if a journalist is able to select a study carefully, other issues may arise. Before making inferences based on study data, journalists should exercise extra caution. One research study does not often signify much on a larger scale, and most study designs offer a great deal of room for uncertainty. It's not always the case that a causes b if a study finds a correlation between a and b. Talking about relative risks instead of absolute hazards has also been criticized because it can give people the wrong idea about what will happen. Let's look at an example related to a hypothetical medical treatment for a certain condition. Let us say that a new drug is being talked about. In a study, there are two groups: Group A took the drug and Group B did not. The study finds that the relative risk of a particular side effect in Group A compared to Group B is 50%. At first look, this might seem important. However, the real risk, or absolute hazard, of the side effect is 1% in Group B and 2% in Group A.

So, while the relative risk increase by 50%, the absolute risk increases only by 1% for Group A. Without considering the absolute hazard, reporting only the relative risk could potentially lead to a misinterpretation. A health report that focuses solely on the relative risk might say something like: "The new medication increases the risk of this side effect by 50%!". However, a more comprehensive report that includes information on absolute hazards could say: "While the relative risk suggests a 50% increase, it's important to note that the actual risk of the side effect is only 2% in the group taking the medication, compared to 1% in the group not taking it."

In this case, the relative risk could be misleading without the context of the absolute hazard, leading to people worrying about the side effect more than is reasonable given the real increase in risk. Giving information on both absolute and relative risks enables a more accurate and nuanced assessment of the given circumstances.

Journalists need to find a good balance between writing about medical news and writing about health and social issues that affect health. Reports may talk about medical services too much and not enough about how much they cost, how good they are, or how strong the evidence is for them. This could make the country's health care costs uneven, which would make it more important to try expensive ideas that have not been shown to work. These are tasks that reporters may not have to do when they are writing about something else. In health news, they are everyday issues.

15.3.3 Inferences from Practicing Health Journalists

The following insights came from the 13th Global Investigative Journalism Conference (GIJC23), where top health investigative reporters from France, Peru, Bangladesh, and the UK talked about their work and the best ways to do investigative health reporting. The collective advice from the experts stressed the need for in-depth research, teamwork, and direct contact with affected people for effective health reporting.

Critical Analysis of Scientific Research: Understand the potential influence of corporations on scientific research in health-related matters. Learn to analyze the regulatory and legal context, investigate funding sources, and background the authors of scientific papers to uncover any manipulation or bias.

Collaboration and Networking: Embrace collaboration with civil society organizations and other journalists, as demonstrated in the investigation of cross-border issues like pesticide use. Building a network and leveraging collaborative efforts can enhance the scope and impact of health investigative reporting.

Effective Use of Databases: Learn to navigate and utilize relevant databases, such as Beyond Pesticides and international guidelines like the International Code of Conduct on Pesticide Management from the World Health Organization (WHO), to gather comprehensive information and support investigative work.

On-the-Ground Reporting: Recognize the significance of on-the-ground reporting and community engagement. Jesmin Papri, one of the experts at the conference, was able to report on how climate change affects reproductive health. This showed how important it is to talk to people directly, including professionals, families, and individuals.

Need to be Fearless Be prepared to face challenges and potential intimidation. Stéphane Horel, another seasoned health journalist at the conference, advised journalists not to be intimidated by authoritative figures or white coats, emphasizing the need for fearlessness in investigative reporting.

15.3.4 Contextualisation

News stories may be chosen based on standard criteria like how timely they are and how important they are. But when writing about health, context is very important. When reporting on research advancements, they must be placed in their proper context. One way to do this is to talk about previous research on the subject, or, in other words, conduct evidence-based reporting, and ask for feedback from outside experts who can help put a new finding in its proper context. Contradictory results are sometimes found in health research. Does a gene link to a sickness? A study finds a link. One doesn't. In these kinds of situations, health writers need to be able to interpret and analyze data. Evidence should help you figure out what the facts are and how to present them in an objective way. Reliability in this case means giving the audience factual, objective information that has been put in its proper context so they can decide how important it is. Being accurate with facts is important, and that means using the right words and numbers.

A good health story gives background on the subject. It gives the reader a bigger picture that helps them figure out where the newest puzzle piece fits in. This kind of writing does more than just repeat what someone said or what research showed. In addition, it looks at the evidence to see how important the topic is. It uses independent experts to help the reader understand what the new information means by looking at what has already been learned. Good health journalism also shows how the subject affects the reader's life and society as a whole.

Although a thorough study should lead to journalism that is based on facts, the stories should also be told in a way that makes them easier for readers to understand and helps them connect with the topic.

15.3.5 Medical Literacy

Medical literacy among health reporters and journalists is very important for making sure that public health information is correct and easy to understand. However, one of the most difficult challenges for health journalists is interpreting medical terminology. Media outlets have trouble verifying medical news stories because it is difficult to translate medical documents and understand doctors' technical language. Further, it is difficult to find trustworthy medical information sources; experts are not always willing or able to check the news; and authorities speak in a language that is difficult to understand.

Medical science is complex and uses specialized terminology, making it difficult for journalists without medical backgrounds to interpret facts. A study conducted among health news reporters in Isfahan found that many of them had not been trained in health reporting and many of them did not understand health issues (Keshvari, M. et al., 2018). A lack of medical literacy can lead to inaccurate and sensationalized reporting. Misleading reporting can harm public health decisions.

Without proper understanding, journalists may overlook medical research's limitations and broader perspectives, lacking context and balance. Health reporters have an ethical obligation to provide accurate and contextualized information because the media heavily influences public health perception, especially during health crises. Medical literacy training for journalists and collaboration between the media and health experts are needed to ensure the public receives accurate and understandable health information.

Check Your Progress: 2

Notes: 1) Use the space below for your answer.

2) Compare your answers with those ones given at the end of this unit.

1. Discuss the importance of health journalists in holding healthcare institutions and professionals accountable for their actions and decisions?

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2. Explore the influence of health journalists in shaping public health policies and initiatives?

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3. Reflect on the challenges faced by health journalists when reporting on emerging health crises?

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15.4 HEALTH POLICY REPORTING

15.4.1 Analyzing the Role of Health Journalists in Covering Healthcare Policies

Health journalists play an important role in society because they help people understand the underlying subtleties of health policies. They explain how the policies work by decoding the hard-to-understand policy language and making the complicated parts of the policy easier to understand. Through their work, they help the public understand the reasons behind policy decisions and how they might affect healthcare services and outcomes. In fact, by showing what issues matter to the public, the press, and policymakers at any given time, health journalists help set the agenda for policymakers. They can also change how people and policymakers see or think about issues by emphasizing certain parts of reality. They can not only change the minds of policymakers but can also change the public's opinion, which then forces policymakers to act.

Using the media to advocate for change is a well-known way to help people understand problems and get policymakers on board with the idea of making things better. Health journalists engage in advocacy for public health while upholding objectivity. They shed light on problems and issues that already exist, as well as possible ways to make health care policies better. As part of their job, they start debates and conversations about health issues or policies, which could lead to changes in public health policy. They discover hidden flaws, conflicts of interest, or unintended consequences within health policies. They act as watchdogs to ensure accountability by monitoring policy implementation, evaluating its impact, and addressing any discrepancies between the intended policy goals and the actual results.

Recognizing that different demographic groups have different healthcare needs and experiences, they base their work on being sensitive to different points of view. Health journalists try to give a full picture by showing how different health policies may affect people differently depending on their race, ethnicity, or location. Engaging with the public through social media, town hall meetings, and community forums, among other media platforms, health journalists create dialogue and spaces for discussions about health policies, which encourages

people to take an active role in the democratic process. What they do basically improves the openness, accountability, and overall effectiveness of how health policies are put into action. It does this by changing how people think about policies and how they are discussed, which is good for everyone's health.

15.4.2 Understanding the Influence of Policy Decisions on Public Health

Policy decisions have a big effect on public health because they affect many parts of the healthcare system and community health as a whole. Access to and coverage of healthcare services are at the heart of this influence, as policies about health insurance and universal healthcare have a big impact on people's ability to get medical care without having to worry about money.

The Pradhan Mantri Jan Arogya Yojana (PMJAY) in India is a good example. This health insurance program, which started in 2018, is meant to protect the finances of more than 100 million vulnerable families, making it easier for them to get medical care without having to worry about money. Policies are also very important when it comes to preventative measures like anti-smoking campaigns and vaccination programs, which help people live healthier lives and stop the spread of diseases. For instance, the Pulse Polio Program of our country. Launched in 1995, this initiative focused on mass vaccination campaigns targeting children under the age of five, ultimately leading to India being declared polio-free in 2014. These rules help people live healthier lives and stop the spread of diseases.

Regulations about the environment are another significant factor that impacts people's health. Since cities and factories are growing quickly, environmental laws are becoming more and more important. The National Air Quality Index (AQI) is an important part of India's plan to clean up the air and protect people's health. This policy promotes cleaner energy sources and keeps an eye on air quality in big cities. It does this by focusing on pollution from vehicles and factories and lowering the risk of health problems related to the environment. Health policies encourage education and awareness, with programs in schools and communities giving people the tools they need to make smart choices and stop the spread of diseases. Similarly, laws that control the sale of tobacco and alcohol, such as taxes, limits on advertising, and warning labels, help improve public health by lowering consumption. Policies also have an effect on food safety and nutrition. For example, rules about food safety and nutrition labeling can change people's eating habits and help with problems like obesity and malnutrition.

Controlling infectious diseases depends a lot on policies that say how to keep an eye on diseases, how to hold people in quarantine, and how many vaccinations people have to get. During pandemics, policy decisions about limiting travel and helping with public health become very important. Regulations and workers' rights in occupational health and safety policies make sure that the workplace is safe and prevent injuries and illnesses that happen at work. Promoting mental health and lowering barriers to care are largely done through mental health policies that include treatment access, anti-stigma campaigns, and funding for services. Lastly, global health diplomacy involves working together and

making policies that deal with health problems that happen across borders. The goal is to fight infectious diseases, make healthcare infrastructure better, and lower health disparities around the world. Basically, policy decisions are what hold public health programs together and make sure that a wide-ranging and effective approach to community health is taken.

Check Your Progress: 3

Notes: 1) Use the space below for your answer.

2) Compare your answers with those ones given at the end of this unit.

1. Evaluate the role of investigative health journalism in uncovering issues such as healthcare fraud, medical malpractice, or unethical pharmaceutical practices.

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2. Discuss the responsibility of health journalists in promoting health equity and addressing disparities in healthcare access and outcomes.

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3. Enumerate on the evolving landscape of health journalism in the digital age.

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15.5 INTERVIEWING IN THE HEALTH CONTEXT

15.5.1 Developing Effective Interviewing Techniques for Health Journalists

If your aim is to become a health journalist, then you must learn how to effectively interview people to get accurate information, explain complicated health issues, and connect with your readers. Here are some important things health reporters should think about and do when they are interviewing people:

1. Know your subject, do a lot of research on the subject, and the person you will be interviewing before the interview. Find out about their background, what they specialize in, and any new work or contributions they have made. With this information, you will be able to ask better, more relevant questions. It is also important to make the person you are interviewing feel at ease. Make sure they understand why they are being interviewed and how their answers will help the public learn about health issues.

2. Use open-ended questions to get detailed answers. Questions that start with "how," "why," or "tell me about" would encourage a more detailed answer. As a follow-up to answers, ask probing questions to make more specific or complicated ideas clearer. This will help you understand the subject better and bring out more details.
3. Pay close attention to what the person being interviewed says. Active listening not only helps you understand what was said, but it also shows that you value the other person's point of view.
4. Keep an open mind during the interview in case something unexpected comes up. The most useful information can sometimes be found in conversations that were not planned. Being flexible is important for capturing these moments.
5. Working as a health journalist often means talking to people and groups from different backgrounds. Be aware of how cultural factors may affect health beliefs and practices, and be sensitive to them.
6. Use plain, easy-to-understand language when talking about technical matters. It is important for health reporters to translate difficult medical or scientific terms into simple language so that their readers can easily understand what they are reading.
7. While discussing personal health related matters, it is important to be mindful of the individual's privacy. You have to respect the boundaries set by the interviewee and clearly inform the person about how the information will be used.
8. In health journalism, accuracy is very important. If you are not sure about something or need more information, do not hesitate to ask the person you interviewed again.
9. After getting permission from the person being interviewed, record the conversation to make sure the report is correct. This lets you go back and read what was said during the conversation, which lowers the chance of misquoting or missing important points.
10. Collect information from a variety of sources to make sure that the health issues you write about reflect their complexity and variety accurately. This means looking at things from different cultural, socioeconomic, and demographic points of view.

15.5.2 Navigating Sensitive Topics with Empathy and Professionalism

As health issues often involve personal and emotionally charged stories, it is important for health journalists to be able to handle sensitive topics with empathy and professionalism. To become a good journalist, you need to understand the feelings of people who are dealing with health problems. Finding a way to connect with interviewees through genuine interest, respect for their experiences, and a promise to accurately represent their points of view is essential for building trust. When writing about mental health, trauma, or

sensitive medical conditions, health reporters must be very careful about the words they use. They must be respectful, empathetic, and free of words that stigmatize or judge.

Communicating the interview or story's purpose and potential impact is essential to informed consent, which is an important ethical requirement while taking interviews. Getting consent makes sure that people being interviewed know how their stories will be shared and gives them control over how much information is shared. Trauma-informed reporting is crucial, and health reporters must note that discussing personal health experiences can cause trauma. Setting up a safe and supportive space for interviews and stories is part of this approach. Further, respecting privacy is very important. Journalists have to find a balance between the public's right to know and a person's right to privacy and stay out of people's personal lives unless they have to.

Diversity and inclusion are important parts of sensitive reporting. For example, health journalists should be aware of and include different points of view. To present information objectively and without personal bias, journalists must stick to professional boundaries. Giving people information about support services is a kind thing to do, especially when the information is about mental health, addiction, or other sensitive topics. As part of this, information about support services, hotlines, or groups that can help should be included. Journalists need to take care of themselves by recognizing the emotional toll that covering tough topics can have and getting help when they need it. Lastly, it is important to deal with concerns in a responsible way. Journalists should respond to feedback and corrections with care and honesty. Using these guidelines can help health journalists talk about issues more empathetically and responsibly.

15.6 MENTAL HEALTH REPORTING

15.6.1 Addressing the Challenges and Responsibilities of Reporting on Mental Health

The challenges of reporting on mental health must be discussed to maintain ethical standards and help people understand this sensitive topic. News about mental health can be hard, and there is a chance that it could spread stigma and false information. Media portrayals that are sensationalized can reinforce stereotypes and make it harder for people to get help. Concerns about privacy also come up, so reporters have to find a fine line between being open and protecting people's right to privacy. Another problem is that mental health problems are very complicated and need to be understood in depth so that they are not oversimplified or misunderstood.

As a result of these problems, mental health reporters have some duties. It is important to spread accurate information, which means you need to make a commitment to keep up with the latest research, treatments, and developments in the field. Staying away from sensationalism is very important if you want to stop stigma and false information from spreading. It is very important to respect the privacy and dignity of people with mental health conditions. This means that journalists must get informed consent and put the well-being of those sharing their experiences first. Language and framing are very important.

They must take special care to avoid using words that are degrading and must present stories in a kind, non-degrading way.

It is also important for health reporters to offer helpful resources while spreading a message of hope and healing. For instance, a list of mental health resources, such as helplines and support groups, would be helpful for people who need them. It is important to continuously educate the audience by providing clear explanations of the complexities surrounding mental health conditions and dispelling any misconceptions. Working alongside mental health experts improves the precision and comprehensiveness of reporting, guaranteeing that information is well-researched and aligned with current advancements. Finally, it is crucial for journalists to prioritize their well-being and seek assistance to avoid burnout. They should be aware of the emotional toll that reporting on mental health can have and take steps to take care of themselves.

15.6.2 Destigmatizing Mental Health Through Accurate and Compassionate Journalism

The stigma surrounding mental health has been around for a long time. This is usually because of false information, sensationalism, and negative media portrayals. Getting a clear and academic understanding of mental health problems is important to fight stereotypes and false beliefs that get in the way of open communication. Stigmatization can have serious repercussions, such as discouraging people from seeking help, fostering feelings of shame, and escalating the isolation that those with mental health issues experience. Using sensationalised or false information in the news about mental health issues reinforces this cycle and highlights the need for a shift toward more accurate and caring reporting. A more nuanced understanding of mental health can only come from accurate reporting that challenges these harmful stories. By providing precise and empathetic coverage, journalism has the potential to reduce the stigma surrounding mental health. This form of reporting has the potential to diminish the stigma surrounding mental health and foster a climate of comprehension and compassion.

There is no doubt that journalists have a huge impact on how people think and feel. Recognizing this duty, there is an increasing demand for journalists to handle mental health reporting with sensitivity, compassion, and a dedication to precision. It is crucial to prioritize the welfare of individuals above sensationalism and to challenge stereotypes through thoughtful and well-informed storytelling.

To accurately represent mental health issues, we need to go beyond one-dimensional portrayals. Being aware that mental health problems are complicated and affect people from all walks of life, journalists should try to include a wide range of experiences. Emphasizing the human aspect and highlighting the themes of recovery and strength can be effective in challenging stereotypes.

Language holds significant influence in shaping perceptions. It is important for journalists to be mindful of their language choices, refraining from using stigmatizing terms and instead opting for terminology that demonstrates a compassionate understanding of mental health. Promoting the use of respectful language plays a crucial role in diminishing stigma and cultivating a discourse that is more inclusive.

Recognizing the difficulties at hand, journalists have the ability to shed light on success stories and positive results pertaining to mental health. Highlighting narratives of resilience, recovery, and the efficacy of treatment can serve as a source of inspiration and provide a counterweight to the predominantly negative stories prevalent in media coverage. Collaboration with mental health professionals and advocacy organizations is crucial for journalists to maintain accuracy and sensitivity in their reporting. Consulting with experts not only enhances the credibility of the reporting but also offers a more nuanced and informed perspective on mental health matters.

15.7 GLOBAL HEALTH JOURNALISM

15.7.1 Examining Global Health Challenges and the Role of Journalists

Technology, transportation, electronic communication, and shared interests have all contributed to the world's growing interconnectedness. Given that diseases can spread exponentially faster than they did even a generation ago, global health issues in this context merit careful examination. While technology helps us live easier lives, it also has a negative side when it allows bacteria and viruses to spread quickly and infect people on the other side of the world. We all have an increasing responsibility to be aware that a small outbreak of illness can spread globally and turn into a pandemic if it is not properly contained. This includes governments, nongovernmental organizations (NGOs), the private health care sector, pharmaceutical companies, and research and development organisations.

Journalists have a crucial role in addressing the complex issues of global health. They serve as important sources of information, educators, and advocates. Their duty to give correct and timely information is of the utmost importance during pandemics and the development of infectious diseases. Media professionals have to find a fine balance between breaking important news and keeping people from panicking. Coverage of vaccines and fighting false information are important parts of their job. Responsible reporting can change people's minds about vaccines and help people who are not sure about getting them. Beyond covering crises, journalists do a lot to bring attention to global health disparities by highlighting the big differences in access to healthcare and fighting for fairness.

Another area where journalists can make a big difference is where climate change and health meet. By writing about the health effects of climate change, like how it can cause diseases to spread and healthcare systems to break down, we can make more people aware of the problem and get everyone to work together to solve it. Healthcare innovations and breakthroughs are written about in the news, which teaches people about cutting-edge developments and gives them hope.

Journalists play an important role in global health governance, where they look into and report on efforts made by countries to work together to solve problems. Communities are important to this conversation, and journalists need to include them in health issues conversations so that people can take an active role in

their own well-being. Data journalism has become a powerful tool that makes it possible to see complicated health data and learn more about health trends around the world. But publishing data comes with a lot of responsibility, like making sure the information is clear and correct and considering ethical issues.

As journalists look into these complicated issues, they run the risk of putting their own safety and health at risk. Risks to a journalist's physical and mental health as well as their support networks must be considered when covering health crises and infectious disease exposure. For the most part, journalists play a much larger role in global health than just reporting; their responsibilities also include advocacy, teaching, and building a community that places a high value on everyone's health and well-being.

15.7.2 Understanding Cultural Nuances in Health Reporting

To make sure that your reporting is accurate, respectful, and useful, you need to know a lot about cultural differences in order to work as a global health journalist. Being culturally sensitive in health journalism means recognizing and respecting different beliefs, practices, and taboos. Journalists need to change the way they talk and write to fit the cultural norms of their audience. They need to be aware that these choices can have a big effect on how health information is received. Traditional healing methods, which often coexist with modern medicine, should be recognized and covered fairly so that people can get a full picture of how healthcare systems work. It is very important for journalists to be aware of the taboos and stereotypes that surround health issues. They should work to de-stigmatize topics while also acknowledging the cultural factors that shape these ideas.

People's religious beliefs affect how they take care of their health and how they think about things like organ donation, birth control, and end-of-life care. Different cultures have very different views on mental health, which means that different points of view need to be explored and respected. Gender roles also affect health reporting, and objective coverage requires an understanding of how cultural norms affect the health experiences of various genders. By focusing on the cultural meanings of local health practices and rituals, we can gain a deeper understanding of healthcare in certain communities. Community engagement is essential because it prevents the perpetuation of stereotypes and misconceptions through working with local leaders, healthcare providers, and individuals to ensure accurate representation. To improve awareness and their ability to navigate delicate subjects and communicate effectively in a variety of cultural contexts, journalists should receive training in cultural competence.

15.8 DIGITAL MEDIA AND HEALTH COMMUNICATION

15.8.1 Exploring the Impact of Digital Media on Health Communication

Digital media has a huge effect on health communication, completely changing how information is shared in the healthcare field. Digital platforms

make it easy for health information to get around quickly. This means that people all over the world can get news and advice almost instantly, which is especially important during health emergencies. People can now obtain more information about their health as a result of information democratization. This encourages patient engagement and shared decision-making.

Social media plays a key role in building communities around health issues, making it easier for people to get involved, build support networks, and spread health campaigns to a wide range of people. Interactive websites, apps, and online communities can all be used to promote health and change people's behaviour. This can help people live healthier lives and stick to their treatment plans. Organizations now use social media to spread their message, rally support, and raise money for global health advocacy and awareness campaigns. The effectiveness of digital media in communicating intricate health information is further improved by personalizing health communication with targeted messages and interactive educational tools. Digital progress has made telehealth possible, which has changed the way healthcare is delivered by allowing remote consultations and more people to get medical help, especially in areas that do not have enough doctors.

But living in the digital world has its problems. Worries about data privacy and security come up when sensitive health data is collected through health apps, wearable tech, and electronic health records. Concerns about health misinformation spreading quickly through digital channels loom large as well. Prioritizing media literacy is very essential to combat this. While navigating this ever-changing landscape, it is crucial to tackle issues like data privacy and misinformation while utilizing digital media to its fullest potential for better public health outcomes through improved health communication.

15.8.2 Leveraging Social Media Responsibly in Health Journalism

In this age of instantaneous information sharing, it is imperative that health journalism responsibly utilizes social media. Before sharing information on social media, journalists should verify its accuracy and credibility by consulting reliable, evidence-based sources. Attributing data to reputable organizations or experts and being open and honest about where the information came from are two of the most important ways to build trust. Content should be balanced in its presentation of health information and should not be sensationalized or click-baited in order to inform rather than scare. Participating in meaningful conversations with your audience on social media helps build a community that values reliable health information by encouraging constructive dialogue. In order to promote health literacy, it is necessary to give background information, define medical terms, and simplify difficult concepts. Important factors to keep in mind include: adhering to ethical standards; protecting privacy; and getting informed consent for personal stories. In order to stop the spread of false information, it is crucial to verify user-generated content. Reporters must try to be inclusive by considering different viewpoints and cultural sensitivities when using social media to reach a wide range of audiences. The credibility

of social media health journalism is enhanced by promptly publishing updates and corrections, working in tandem with experts, and guaranteeing responsible engagement.

15.9 HANDLING HEALTH DATA AND EXPERTS

15.9.1 Communicating Health Data

In health journalism, getting health information across requires a multifaceted approach that puts accuracy, openness, and ease of access first. Journalists must make sure that health data is correct and reliable by getting their information from trustworthy sources and writing clear reports that explain the background, methods, and any possible limitations. Using data visualization tools like graphs and charts can help make complicated information easier to understand. Additionally, using plain language and putting things in their proper context can help people understand technical terms better. Health journalists help the public make informed decisions by distinguishing long-term trends from short-term fluctuations and communicating health risks without sensationalism.

Interactive data platforms allow users to explore health data personally, fostering engagement and understanding. Journalists should focus on how health data affects public policy, examining and documenting the ways in which statistics affect policy choices. Maintaining trust in data reporting requires ethical considerations, such as protecting privacy and avoiding sensationalism. Participation of the community in the data collection process builds trust and a sense of ownership in the community. It also makes the information more reliable.

15.9.2 Building Relationships with Health Professionals

Health journalists who want to write accurate and nuanced stories about health must build strong relationships with health professionals. These partnerships are built on trust, which is established between parties via openness, deference to knowledge, and a commitment to accuracy. It is critical to communicate clearly in order to guarantee that expectations are met and issues are quickly resolved. Journalists must recognize the responsibilities and constraints placed on health professionals, respecting their knowledge while also appreciating the boundaries of their practice. It is crucial for journalists to be considerate and adaptable when arranging interviews or meetings in order to honor the time constraints of busy healthcare professionals. Additionally, by actively seeking clarification and insights from medical professionals, journalists can further develop their understanding of medical topics and create a collaborative learning environment.

It is advantageous to include health experts in the story development process since it guarantees that the finished product is accurate and thorough. To present a balanced understanding of health issues, it is important to actively seek out diverse perspectives within the healthcare industry. In order to preserve the veracity and accuracy of information, journalists have to closely collaborate with experts in fact-checking and verification. When discussing potentially difficult or delicate subjects, it is important to be sensitive and recognize the effects on the professionals and the individuals

who are involved. Acknowledging and respecting the knowledge of medical professionals improves the working relationship and promotes a productive and win-win partnership. Relationships with health professionals help create well-informed, accurate, and ethical health journalism that informs the public about important health issues.

15.10 LET US SUM UP

Health journalism is the dissemination of health-related information to the public via media outlets in order to keep people informed and to assist in the development of some level of health literacy among the general public. Raising public awareness is critical for promoting individual and community health, preventing illness, reducing stigma, and generally improving societal well-being. Public awareness and understanding of health issues and conditions play an additional important role in national health management by assisting in effective healthcare resource allocations and focusing governmental attention on prevalent health problems and challenges, ultimately leading to people-friendly policies.

A lack of scientific knowledge is one of the most common problems encountered by journalists covering scientific subjects. The ability of a health reporter to judge the quality of a research paper is critical because selecting a poorly designed study may result in the unintentional dissemination of skewed, biased, and incomplete news and information. Furthermore, journalists must investigate the legal and regulatory environment, research funding, experts, and authors to determine how corporations may influence scientific reports. When delving into investigative health journalism, health reporters should cultivate skills in critical analysis, collaboration, database utilization, on-the-ground reporting, and maintaining a fearless approach. Interpreting medical terminology is another challenge for health journalists. Medical literacy training for journalists, as well as collaboration between the media and health experts, are required to ensure that the public receives accurate and understandable health information.

To become a health journalist, one must first learn how to conduct effective interviews in order to obtain accurate information, explain complex health issues, and connect with readers. Honing interviewing skills would help health reporters produce more accurate, useful, and ethically and culturally sensitive news. Health journalists must be able to handle sensitive topics with empathy and professionalism. For example, mental health journalism necessitates a meticulous and accountable approach that considers the field's unique challenges as well as journalists' ethical obligations. In this day and age of instantaneous information sharing, health journalism must use social media responsibly. Before sharing information on social media, journalists should double-check its accuracy and credibility by consulting reliable, evidence-based sources. Health journalists who want to write accurate and nuanced stories about health must build strong relationships with health professionals. Involving health experts in the story development process ensures that the finished product is accurate and comprehensive.

15.11 FURTHER READINGS

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5. [Effects of news coverage on policy attention and actions: A closer look into the media-policy connection; I Yanovitzky](#)

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15.12 CHECK YOUR PROGRESS: POSSIBLE ANSWERS

Check Your Progress: 1

1. Health journalists bridge scientific findings with public understanding, but translating complexity poses challenges in maintaining accuracy. They strive to convey medical nuances in accessible language without oversimplifying or sensationalizing, ensuring informed decision-making among diverse audiences.
2. Health journalists grapple with ethical dilemmas when covering sensitive health topics. They navigate privacy concerns, respect cultural sensitivities, and uphold accuracy while debunking myths. Balancing transparency and

sensitivity, they foster trust and credibility in reporting on mental health, infectious diseases, and medical controversies.

3. Health journalists combat misinformation by verifying sources, scrutinizing claims, and providing evidence-based reporting. They employ fact-checking methods, engage with experts, and prioritize accuracy over sensationalism. Through transparent and credible reporting, they empower the public to make informed health decisions amidst an onslaught of falsehoods.

Check Your Progress: 2

1. Health journalists serve as watchdogs, holding healthcare institutions and professionals accountable. They investigate malpractice, corruption, and inequities while respecting patient privacy and confidentiality. Balancing transparency and sensitivity, they spotlight issues of public concern and advocate for systemic improvements in healthcare delivery and governance.
2. Health journalists influence public health policies by informing discourse, highlighting pressing issues, and advocating evidence-based solutions. Their reporting shapes public opinion, mobilizes communities, and holds policy makers accountable. By amplifying marginalized voices and promoting health equity, they contribute to more inclusive and effective healthcare systems.
3. Health journalists navigate the delicate balance of reporting on health crises. They provide timely, accurate information while mitigating panic and misinformation. By collaborating with experts, verifying sources, and prioritizing public safety, they play a crucial role in fostering informed decision-making and resilience during emergencies.

Check Your Progress: 3

1. Investigative health journalism exposes healthcare fraud, malpractice, and unethical practices. Through rigorous research, interviews, and data analysis, journalists uncover systemic failures and advocate for accountability. By amplifying whistleblowers' voices and exposing wrongdoing, they catalyze reforms and improve patient safety and trust in healthcare systems.
2. Health journalists advocate for health equity by spotlighting disparities and amplifying marginalized voices. They challenge stereotypes, combat stigma, and raise awareness of social determinants of health. By prioritizing inclusive and empathetic reporting, they empower communities, drive policy change, and foster more equitable healthcare access and outcomes.
3. Health journalism evolves in the digital age, leveraging technology and social media for broader reach and engagement. Journalists adapt to changing consumption habits, embrace multimedia storytelling, and engage with audiences through interactive platforms. While facing challenges of misinformation and echo chambers, they leverage digital tools to foster informed dialogue and uphold journalistic integrity.

UNIT 16 BEHAVIOURAL CHANGE COMMUNICATION IN HEALTH CARE

Structure

- 16.0 Introduction
- 16.1 Learning Outcomes
- 16.2 Behavioural Change Communication in Health Care: Meaning and Benefits
 - 16.2.1 Meaning of BCC in Health Care
 - 16.2.2 Benefits of BCC
- 16.3 Channels of Behavioural Change Communication
 - 16.3.1 Tips for Effective Interpersonal Communication
 - 16.3.2 Tips for Effective Mass Communication
- 16.4 Strategies of Behavioural Change Communication
- 16.5 Guidelines for Successful Behavioural Change Communication
- 16.6 Barriers to Behaviour Change of Communication in Health Care
 - 16.6.1 Socio-Cultural Barriers
 - 16.6.2 Health Services
 - 16.6.3 Socio-economic Conditions and Infrastructure Facilities
 - 16.6.4 Lacunas in Behavioural Change Communication Methods and Channels
- 16.7 Let Us Sum Up
- 16.8 Further Readings
- 16.9 Check Your Progress: Possible Answers

16.0 INTRODUCTION

Nowadays many health care programmes in most countries, particularly in developing countries, are using behavioural change communication (BCC) to improve the health status and well-being of its people. Generally speaking BCC is a process that motivates people to adopt and sustain healthy behaviours and lifestyle. A comprehensive BCC strategy would be helpful to effectively implement BCC activities in order to improve health status of the population. It is pertinent to mention here that BCC is one of the health care education strategies outlined in the Uttar Pradesh National Rural Health Mission (NRHM) to achieve the goals of reduction in mortality, fertility and morbidity.

16.1 INTRODUCTION

After reading this unit you should be able to:

- explain the meaning and benefits of BCC in family health care;
 - discuss various channels of BCC;
 - how to formulate a BCC strategy; and
 - describe and follow guidelines for successful BCC.
-

16.2 BEHAVIOURAL CHANGE COMMUNICATION IN HEALTH CARE: MEANING AND BENEFITS

National Health Policy (1982) emphasised on appropriate communication strategies to provide health information in easily understandable form and to motivate formation of an attitude for healthy living. Communication is derived from a Latin word “Communis” which means common. When we communicate, we are trying to establish commonness with someone. It is the way which provides a link between two individuals or an individual and the world outside himself / herself.

16.2.1 Meaning of BCC in Health Care

Some of the definitions of BCC are narrated below.

- BCC in health aims at to improve people’s health and well-being including education about maternal and child health care, health care of adolescents and the elderly, family planning and communicable and non-communicable diseases.
- The BCC in health care is customarily a process that motivates people to adopt and sustain healthy behaviours and lifestyle. A sustained BCC programme.
- leads to improvement in the health status of people. Behavioural Change Communication strategy in health refers to systematic attempts to modify and influence behaviour or practices; and environmental factors related to that behaviour which directly or indirectly promotes use of healthy practices.
- Behavioural Change Communication (BCC) is the strategic use of communication to promote positive health outcomes based on proven theories and models of behaviour change.
- According to Bertrand and Becker- Benton, the main difference between IEC (Information, Communication and Education) and BCC is that while IEC stresses one-way communication focused on “Messages”, BCC is more “Outcome” oriented and also includes the role of participatory methods and motivation in the behavioural changes process.
- Behavioural change communication is part of an integrated, multi-level, interactive process with communities, aimed at developing tailored messages and approaches using a variety of communication channels.

- Behavioural Change Communication uses behavioural and communication theories and research to develop interventions that influences individual behaviours and the social contexts in which they occur.

What is Behaviour Change Communication?

BCC is about changing specific behaviours – “well defined actions at the household, community and health service levels”. BCC approaches recognize that behaviour change is more about identifying the causes and barriers to behaviour change and overcoming the barriers. It is about understanding the communities, contexts and environments in which behaviours occur. BCC is also about using persuasive techniques to demand health rights and to make public sector health services available and accessible to the neediest. BCC is about integrating new practices into long standing social, cultural and communication systems.

What is Behaviour Change Communication?

BCC is a research-based, consultative process of addressing knowledge, attitudes, and practices through identifying, analyzing, and segmenting audiences and participants in programs and by providing them with relevant information and motivation through well-defined strategies, using an appropriate mix of interpersonal, group and mass-media channels, including participatory methods.

Neill McKee

16.2.2 Benefits of BCC

Behaviour change communication (BCC) is the strategic use of communication to promote positive health outcomes, based on proven theories and models of behaviour change. BCC employs a systematic process beginning with formative research and behaviour analysis, followed by communication planning, implementation, and monitoring, evaluation and follow-up activities. Audiences are carefully segmented; messages and materials are pre-tested, and both mass media and interpersonal channels are used to achieve defined behavioural objectives.

BCC aims to foster positive behaviour; promote and sustain individual, community and societal behaviour change and maintain appropriate behaviour.

Some of the important benefits of BCC are as follows:

- Increases knowledge, attitude and skill
- Stimulates community dialogue
- Promotes essential attitude change
- Creates demand for information and services
- Advocates for appropriate family health care policies
- Enhances use of promotive, preventive and curative health care services Is more appropriate for the illiterate and less literate group of audiences
- In this section you read about the meaning and benefits of BCC, now answer the questions given in Check Your Progress: 1

Check Your Progress: 1

Note: 1) Use the space provided below for your answers.

2) Compare your answers with those given at the end of the unit.

1) What do you mean by BCC?

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2) What are the benefits of BCC?

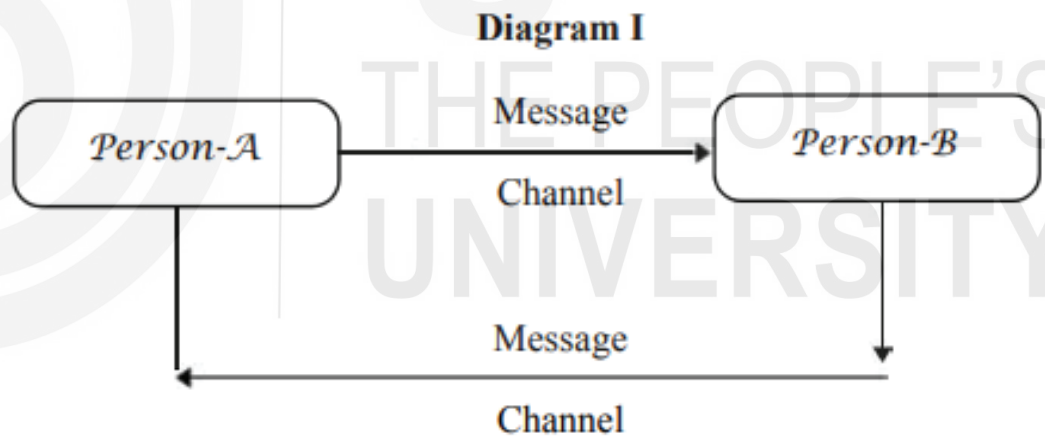
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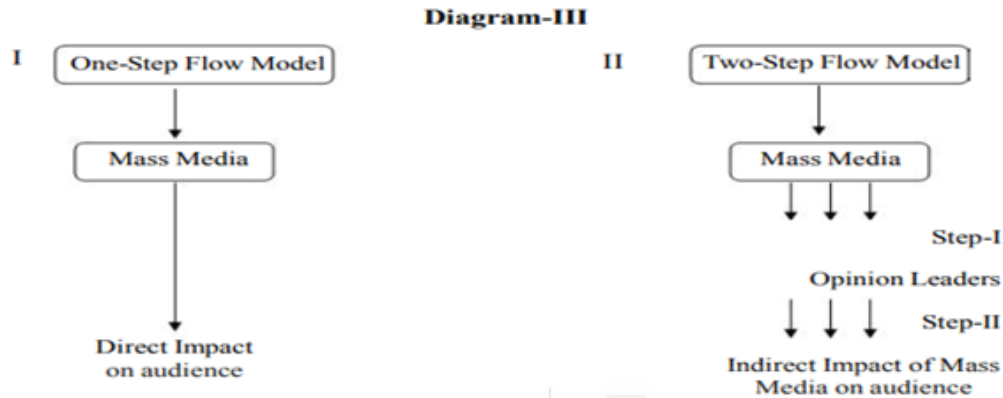
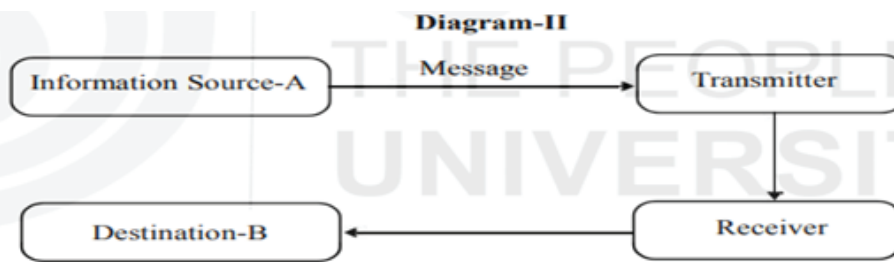
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16.3 CHANNELS OF BEHAVIOURAL CHANGE COMMUNICATION

Various channels are used in the process of communication. All these channels intend, either directly or indirectly, to pass on information from one source to the other. The simplest model of communication is represented in Diagram-I.



Sometimes the message can be transmitted through mass media i.e. radio, television etc. In Diagram-I, person-B who is listening to that message was broadcast by information source-A. The communication processes are concerned with the flow of information from one source to that of the other. The Diagram- I is the face-to-face communication or two-way communication process, while Diagram-II describes the mediated communication, where a variety of means of communication are used.



Mass communication denotes message transfer via such mass media as newspapers, magazines, films, radio and television— which enables a message to reach an audience of many. Early researchers in mass communication thought the mass media were powerful tools in influencing an individual's attitudes and behaviours. The two-step flow of communication (Diagram-III) is probably the most exciting idea of communication research. It is postulated on the principle that ideas often flow from mass media to opinion leaders and from them to the less active sections of the population.

Rogers (1962) found that mass media communication is more important in changing cognition, whereas interpersonal communication is more likely to cause attitude change. While Chacko (1980) in his study concluded that the effect of mass media like cinema, drama and folk arts is more pronounced among the respondents. The channels of communication and their characteristics are represented in Table-3.1 and 3.2. The channels of interpersonal communication to be used for BCC by the health personnel for the propagation of health and family welfare messages in the countryside are through neighbours, youth club members, Panchayat members, Mahila Mandal members etc., while for interpersonal communication, the functionaries of the line departments can be used for BCC.

Table 16.1: Point of Origin

Nature of Channel	Local	Non-local
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Interpersonal	i) Neighbour ii) Relative iii) Village Panchayat members iv) Youth organisation members v) Women's organisation members vi) Opinion leaders vii) Shopkeepers viii) Co-operative members	i) Extension Agents ii) Wandering story-tellers iii) Salesman iv) Health Workers v) Village Development Officers
Mass Media	i) Village newspaper ii) Wall posters	i) Radio ii) Television iii) Cinema iv) City newspaper

However, the effectiveness of both interpersonal and mass media channels depends on the characteristics of communication which are explained in Table-16.2. The pace of flow of information through interpersonal and mass media depends on these characteristics.

Table 16.2: Characteristics of Communication

Communication Characteristics		Interpersonal Channel	Mass Media Channel
1.	Direction of message flow	Two-way	One-way
2.	Speed to a large audience	Slow	Rapid
3.	Message accuracy to large audience	Low	High
4.	Ability to select receiver	High	Low
5.	Ability to overcome selectivity processes	High	Low
6.	Amount of feedback	High	Low
7.	Possible effect	Attitude change	Increased Knowledge

In this section you read about the various channels of BCC, now answer the questions given in Check Your Progress: 2.

Check Your Progress: 2

Note: 1) Use the space provided below for your answers.
 2) Compare your answers with those given at the end of the unit.

1) Draw a diagram for a two-way channel of communication.

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- 2) What are the various channels of interpersonal and mass communication of local origin?

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16.3.1 Tips for Effective Interpersonal Communication

- Introduce yourself
- Explain the purpose of visit
- Establish mutual understanding
- Allow the audience to speak more than you do and facilitate the discussion
- Win the confidence of the audience
- Understand their problems
- Analyse whether your interest and his/ or her problems are the same or different
- Do not make false promises / pose as someone else

16.3.2 Tips for effective Mass Communication

- Use real or fictional stories that illustrate real situations, actions and consequences
- Use credible characters and make use of people in the campaign message, who care for, and are liked and respected by the masses
- Address the most immediate health and family welfare problem
- Expose the audience to multiple messages and multi channels. Messages that work together and build on each other through different media; print, news, radio, television, posters, have more influence than any one media method only.

Be realistic and remember that campaign messages are only one source of influence. Do not expect revolutionary changes.

Skill Required for Interpersonal Communication Listening Skill

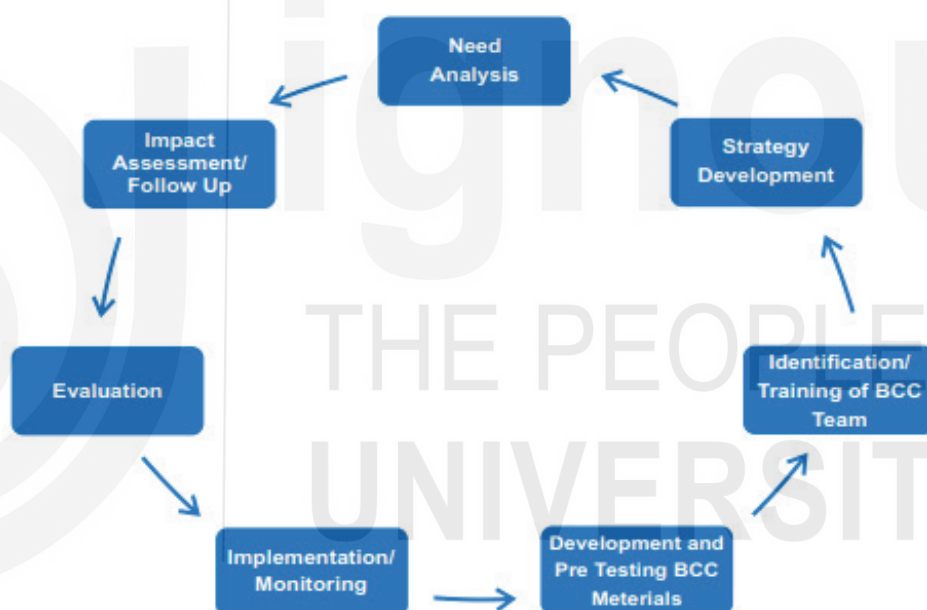
- Keep your mind open Be flexible
- Fond area of interest Listen to ideas
- Judge content not delivery Resist distractions
- Hold your tire Work at listening
- Capitalize on thought speed

Speaking Skill

- Face the audience Maintain eye contact
- Use appropriate aids if required Use appropriate language
- Focus on the needs of the audience
- Be brief, to the point, without ambiguous
- Give chance other to speak Communicate with clarity Speak in local language

16.4 STRATEGIES OF BEHAVIOURAL CHANGE COMMUNICATION

The successful implementation of BCC programme depends on an effective BCC strategy. The BCC strategy uses BCC programme cycle for the systemic implementation of BCC programme.

**Step-1 Need Analysis:**

Step-2: Strategy Development

Step-3: Identification and Training of BCC team

Step-4: Development and Pre-testing of BCC materials

Step-5: Implementation and Monitoring of BCC programme Step-6: Evaluation

Step-7: Impact Assessment / Follow-Up

Step-1: Need Analysis- During the process of need analysis, the BCC experts have to find out:

- Firstly, identification of various needs and issues in the area. For example, in some areas the need may be control of communicable diseases, while in other areas it may be promotion of MCH care.

- ii) Secondly, the characteristics of population i.e. gender, caste, ethnicity, etc. It is true that the health care needs vary from community to community. The health care needs of tribal communities may differ from those of non-tribal communities.
- iii) Lastly, which aspects of family health care issues can be addressed through communication?

It is important to study the primary and secondary audiences carefully. Primary audiences are those who are suffering from health problems; while secondary audiences are those who influence health problems of the primary audience. For example, in case of ante-natal care of rural women, the primary audience is the ante-natal mother and the secondary audiences are the TBA (Traditional Birth Attendant) and other local health care providers.

Collect in-depth information about the knowledge, attitudes and beliefs about health and health care practices, information seeking habits and their (audience's) access to various channels of BCC.

Another important dimension of need analysis is the categorisation of behaviour of the clientele. The behaviour in BCC can be "Priority Behaviours" and "Specific Behaviours". A priority behaviour is the main outcome or expected behavioural change. While, the specific behaviour is the set of ancillary behaviours may be required for priority behaviour. For example, in antenatal care, the "Early Registration" is the outcome or priority behaviour. However, to reach this "Early Registration" outcome behaviour, the early detection of pregnancy at the community level through identification of symptoms and testing of urine, etc. are the specific or ancillary behaviour.

Step-2: Strategy Development- It is the most important stage and in this stage the following points are largely taken care of:

- i) The goal and objectives of BCC programme is clearly identified. While doing so, it has to be ensured that the objectives are SMART-Specific, Measurable, Appropriate, Realistic and Time-bound.
- ii) Develop a framework and show how the BCC programme activities would be helpful in achieving programme goals and objectives of health and family welfare.
- iii) Prioritising the various channels of BCC. Here the co-operation of community and community leaders must be resorted. A few questions needed to be put to the strategy formulators here are:
 - a) Are messages accurate and meaningful?
 - b) Whether messages are clear, concise, relevant and appealing to the audience?

Step-3: Identification and Training of BCC Team- The third step is to choose a media team. People with experience in health communication must be given preference. The composition of the team must be in such a way that it will comprise both technical and generalist. The individual having knowledge with development of BCC materials would be of great help. To be precise, the team needs to comprise health, nursing and health related and media personnel.

Step-4: Development and Pre-Testing of BCC Materials- Once the BCC team is selected, the duty of the team is to prepare BCC materials and pre-test it over a sample before finally go to larger audience. The good quality BCC materials must have following characteristics.

- i) Should be accurate
- ii) Should be clear and consistent
- iii) Should be relevant and based on the needs of the audience
- iv) Should be appealing
- v) Should be sensitive to gender differences

Step-5: Implementation and Monitoring- After the development of BCC materials, the implementation process starts. It is pertinent that the BCC team should mobilise a large number of stakeholders who want to provide help to implement activities and develop a broad sense of ownership. Involve the stakeholders and a few active audiences. These audiences also may be involved in the monitoring and assessment of BCC materials for making recommendations, and further improvement of BCC activities and materials. An example of priority areas of BCC campaign in NRHM in Uttar Pradesh is given below (Box-16.1).

Box 16.1: Priority for BCC Campaigns- 14 Core Trigger Behaviours

1.	Delay first pregnancy before 21 years for girls
2.	Eat three times a day (women and adolescent girls); eat 3-4 times a day (pregnant women)
3.	Early registration before 12 weeks; 3 ANC check ups
4.	Institutional delivery; Stay in the hospital for 24 hours after delivery
5.	Immediate health seeking behaviour on recognition of danger signs in mother and newborn
6.	Immediate and exclusive breast feeding within one hour of birth and continue exclusive breast feeding up to six months
7.	Keep the newborn warm with mother lap (skin to skin)
8.	Complete immunisation / Booster / Vitamin A
9.	Complementary feeding from six months 4-5 times a day in addition to breast feeding
10.	Wash hands with soap after defecation and prior to feeding child
11.	Increase birth interval to three years
12.	Adopt any limiting method after first two children even if both are girls
13.	Early detection of tuberculosis (TB)
14.	Empty and dry the water containers once a week

Source: Behavioural Change Communication (BCC) strategy for NRHM in Uttar Pradesh, Government of Uttar Pradesh, November, 2008.

Step-6: Evaluation- In this stage following three activities are to be conducted:

- i) Measure outcomes and assess impact

- ii) Disseminate results to partners, key stake holders, the news media and funding agencies.
- iii) Record lesson learned and archive research finding for use in future programs.

Step-7: Follow up: The last step in the BCC strategy is follow up. If it is an action research programme, then the BCC Team has to follow up it usually after six month and collect the gaps in activities and materials from the clientele. Then revise or redesign programme based on both evaluation and follow up.

16.5 GUIDELINES FOR SUCCESSFUL BEHAVIOURAL CHANGE COMMUNICATION

Guidelines for Successful Communication

A successful communication strategy depends on some factors which must be adhered to before initiating the communication process. These are as follows:

- i) **Avoid Communication Under the Influence of Emotions:** Emotional state influences the effectiveness of communication. If either party is in a heightened emotional state because of some incident, good communication is going to be very difficult. It is better not to even try to communicate if someone is extremely upset, as they need a cooling-off period before trying to work out the issues. A little deep breathing with eyes closed can do wonders. Postponing the communication for the time being or it is better to avoid communication if someone is not in good mood.
- ii) **Controlling Assumptions:** It is good to check your assumptions before communicating. A discussion has a greater **chance** of success if someone assumes that the other has good intentions. Most of the time, even someone says something hurtful to you, it may not have been their intention to hurt you. Give the other the benefit of the doubt and try not to make assumptions about their intentions. Generally in the family and or in an organisation people assume that they know the intentions of others, and it makes them biased. Assumptions can be avoided by simply sticking with “I” messages. It is very difficult to resolve a dispute or calm hurt feelings if we begin by accusing. When we say that we are angry because of what you did or what you said, we are automatically putting the other on the defensive. A successful communication may not be possible when accusations are flying. When you use the word “I,” you are not talking about what the other did or what the other said. You are not accusing or condemning. You are simply sharing your feelings. You are reflecting to the other how their words and/or actions impacted you. You say, “I feel upset when you...” or “I feel hurt when you...” and so on. You are still letting them know that you are hurt and upset but you are talking about your feelings, the impact on you, and not simply blaming or accusing. (Bob Trowbridge)
- iii) **Quality Listening/Listening with Full Concentration:** One of the most effective communication tools is not a form of communication at all. It is listening. Many problems in communication are worsened because we do

not listen to what the other is saying. If we are thinking about how we are going to reply to them while they are still talking, we are not really listening to what they are saying. We are simply trying to give them a befitting reply. Quality listening is missing, important information's are lost. Communication link is distorted. Listening means mentally present with the other person. Really listening is a sign of respect. You can show this kind of respect even if you are angry at the other. Respectful listening can calm a situation down on both sides.

By being present, you are saying that the relationship is important and you want to stay and work it out. We must listen very carefully. It is called "active listening." In active listening, one may interrupt an individual for two different reasons. One is to get clarification. If one doesn't want to be misinterpreted, one can respectfully ask for clarification. The other reason for interrupting has the same goal. One may repeat something back to the person to make sure that he understood clearly, or communicate with a brief note. If you feel that you are not good at verbal communication when you are upset, you might agree with the other person that you will try to gather your thoughts and explain your feelings about the situation in writing. The other person may be willing to do the same. Then you come together and read what the other has written and use that as a springboard for your ongoing communication. The words carry power to hurt and heal. Practising use of good words with proper context can improve communication skill.

- iv) **Use evidence-based communication:** This guiding principle believes in communication supported by true facts, figures and data. It never encourages speculation and guesswork. People, particularly the rural and urban slum dwellers having little knowledge, believe in individuals and other communication media which give true facts and figures and lucidly analyse the facts.
- v) **Prioritising behaviours:** The health and family welfare activists and the communicators who want to propagate health and family welfare messages have to prioritise the communication themes on the basis of their importance. For example, immunisation of children and women has more priority than the family education aspects. In other words prioritisation of essential service delivery is more important.
- vi) **Utilising technology for message dissemination:** A large number of information technology platforms such as the Internet, mobile apps, etc. are being used now a day for the dissemination of health and family welfare messages. The health communicators and education have to use the technology based on the age-group of clientele and areas in which the messages are to be delivered. For example mobile apps and Facebook can be popularly used in transmitting messages on adolescent education than immunisation and family planning services

16.6 BARRIERS TO BEHAVIOUR CHANGE IN COMMUNICATION IN HEALTH CARE

Some of the barriers of behavioural change communication are described below. They are broadly categorised into four types.

16.6.1 Socio-Cultural Barriers

- Gender discrimination/ preference for sons
- Norm of early child bearing / early marriage
- Traditional child feeding practices
- Stereotyped dietary pattern
- Prevalence of religious believes and values

16.6.2 Health Services

- Lack of regular outreach services at the village level
- Health provider attitude and low motivation
- There are no personnel for BCC at sub-centre level
- Poor budgetary allocation for BCC in health and family welfare
- Lack of trust in public sector services
- Lack of professionalism among NGOs delivering services at the grassroots

16.6.3 Socio-economic Conditions and Infrastructure Facilities

- Transport constraints
- Illiteracy and low literacy
- Lack of electricity
- Poverty
- Lack of women empowerment

16.6.4 Lacunas in Behavioural Change Communication Methods and Channels

- Too much focus on awareness creation
- Limited reach of mass media in rural areas
- Weak system of BCC supervision
- Lack of trained BCC personnel
- Community based BCC such as folk media, group meeting, etc. require lot of time and effort
- Some BCC methods suitable for rural areas like wall painting is more costly.

In this session you need about the BCC strategies, now answer the questions given in Check your Progress: 3.

Check Your Progress: 3

- Note:**
- 1) Use the space provided below for your answers.
 - 2) Compare your answers with those given at the end of the unit.

- 1) What are the important steps of need analysis for any intervention in BCC?

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- 2) Describe the socio-cultural barriers of behavioural change communication.

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16.7 LET US SUM UP

Behavioural Change Communication (BCC) plays an important role in creating awareness and developing attitude and skill of both, health service providers and beneficiaries. In this unit you read about the meaning and benefits of BCC. It has delineated various channels of BCC and BCC strategies. The successful carrying out of BCC requires certain guidelines. This unit has also described guidelines for successful conduction of BCC, particularly of inter-personal communication and mass communication.

16.8 FURTHER READINGS

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16.9 CHECK YOUR PROGRESS- POSSIBLE ANSWERS

Check Your Progress: 1

- 1) What do you mean by BCC?

Ans. Behaviour change communication (BCC) is the strategic use of communication to promote development, based on proven theories and models of behaviour change. According to Neill Mackee, BCC is a research-based, consultative process of addressing knowledge, attitudes, and practices through identifying, analysing, and segmenting audiences and participants in programmes and by providing them with relevant

information and motivation through well-defined strategies, using an appropriate mix of interpersonal, group and mass-media channels, including participatory methods.

2) What are the benefits of BCC?

Ans. BCC aims to foster positive behaviour; promote and sustain individual, community and societal behaviour change and maintain appropriate behaviour. Some of the important benefits of BCC are: (a) Increases knowledge, improves attitude and skill (b) Stimulate community dialogue (c) Promote essential attitude change (d) Creates demand for information and services (e) Advocate for appropriate family health care policies (f) Enhances use of promotive, preventive and curative health care services (g) It is more appropriate for the illiterate and less literate group of audiences.

Check Your Progress: 2

1) Draw a diagram for a two-way channel of communication.

Ans. See diagram- III of this unit.

2) What are the various channels of interpersonal and mass communication of local origin?

Ans. Various channels of interpersonal and mass communication of local origin are: (i) neighbour, (ii) relative (iii) village Panchayat members (iv) youth organisation members (v) women organisation members (vi) opinion leaders (vii) shop-keepers (viii) co-operative members.

Check Your Progress: 3

1) What are the important steps of need analysis for any intervention in BCC?

Ans. The process of need analysis is a very important strategy for any intervention. The BCC experts usually follow these steps for need analysis. Firstly, identification of various needs and issues in the area. For example, in some areas the need may be control of communicable diseases, while in other areas it may be promotion of MCH care. Secondly, studying the characteristics of population i.e. gender, caste, ethnicity, etc. It is true that health care needs vary from community to community. The health care needs of tribal communities may differ from those of non-tribal communities.

Lastly, find out which aspects of family health care issues can be addressed through communication?

2) Describe the socio-cultural barriers of behavioural change communication.

Ans. Broadly, there are four types of barriers of behavioural change communication -- socio-cultural barriers, health services, socio-economic conditions and lacunas in BCC methods and channels. Socio-cultural barriers include gender discrimination, norm of early child-bearing / early marriage, traditional child feeding practices, stereotyped dietary patterns, prevalence of religious believes and values.